

My Team Grew From 5 to 20 Overnight. Here's What I Didn't Know.

****Quick Bridge:**** Teams do not lose ground because the work gets worse. They lose ground because the knowledge behind critical work was never shared. Most leaders delegate the task. Almost nobody delegates the reason the task exists. Here is what happens when that gap meets a growing team. One question tells you how exposed yours is right now.

My team went from five people to twenty in what felt like a week.

One month I had five people I knew well, a backlog I could hold in my head, and two years of relationships I had built carefully. The next month I had four times the people, three new workstreams, and a calendar that made the old one look spacious.

The work I had been doing for my original team did not stop needing to get done. But I could not do it anymore. And nobody was behind me to pick up the pieces.

I had spent two years doing things for that team that I never put a name to.

I prioritized the backlog. I met with internal customers. I translated what the team was building into language that made sense to the people who funded our work.

I went to meetings where the team's interests needed a voice. I made sure the right people knew what we were working on and why it mattered.

My team did the actual work. I handled everything around it.

I thought I was being helpful. I was good at it. That felt like the point.

What I did not understand then was what I was actually building.

I was not just doing tasks. I was the only one who knew why those tasks mattered. The context behind them. The reason the work existed.

The relationships. The priorities. The translation between what the team built and what the business cared about. None of that lived anywhere except inside me.

So when I could not do it anymore, it did not get handed off. It just stopped.

The team did not know what had disappeared. They could see I was stretched. They assumed I was still handling things I was no longer handling. And the work that had kept them visible and valued inside the organization quietly faded.

****My original team lost ground for years after that.**** Not because their work got worse. Because nobody knew why the surrounding work existed, so nobody thought to pick it up. It took years for me to convince people that those pieces of work were important, and even longer to do it in a way that made the right impact.

This is the delegation mistake nobody warns you about.

Most leaders think about delegation as a capacity problem. "I am doing too much. I need to hand some of it off." That framing gets the question wrong.

The real question is not "what can I give away?" It is "what does this team need to keep succeeding when I am not here?"

Those are different problems with different solutions.

When I handed things off in those early years, I taught people how to do tasks. How to run the backlog meeting. How to format the status update. How to prepare for the quarterly review.

****What I never taught was why those things existed.**** Why the internal customer relationship was weight-bearing, not optional. Why making the team's work visible was not self-promotion. It was the thing standing between our team and obscurity.

When people do not know why a piece of work matters, they make reasonable decisions to let it slide. They are not wrong to do that. They are working without the context that would have told them not to.

I came back from that period with a question I now ask about every critical piece of work I own:

Does someone else on this team know WHY this exists, not just what it is?

Not: can they do the task? Not: do they know the steps? But: do they understand why the business or the team depends on this work?

If the answer is no, that is the delegation conversation I need to have. Not "can you take this off my plate?" but "let me show you why this work exists and what happens if it stops."

Here is what that looks like in practice.

****Name the work that only you do.**** Not your formal responsibilities. The informal ones. The things you do because you have been around long enough to know they matter, but that nobody has put in writing.

Those are the places where the team is most dependent on you, and the most likely to quietly break when you are not there.

****Teach the why before the how.**** When you bring someone into a new area, start with the problem the work solves, not the tasks involved in solving it. A person who understands the purpose will adapt when circumstances change. A person who only knows the steps will stop when the steps do not fit the situation.

****Build the backup before you need one.**** The team expansion will not wait for you to have a transition plan ready. The time to do this is when things are quiet, not when the calendar is already on fire.

The vacation test is a useful gut check. If you cannot take two weeks off without worrying about whether certain work will continue, you have not delegated. You have just kept yourself as a single point of failure.

The team I have now knows why the work matters. They know which relationships cannot go quiet. A few of them have grown into roles where they are passing that same knowledge to their own teams.

These days I can take a vacation without checking my phone. Turns out that is what delegation was actually supposed to feel like.

****This week:**** Think about the one piece of work you would scramble most to cover if you suddenly could not. You know which one it is.

Ask yourself honestly: does anyone on your team know WHY that work exists? Not just what it is. Not just how to do it. Why the team depends on it.

If the answer is no, that is your next conversation. Not "here, take this." But "let me show you what this actually does for us."

Have you ever watched a team lose ground after a key person stepped away? What was the first thing that disappeared?

You're great at the work. Let's make you impossible to ignore.

If you are looking for help building a team that does not depend on you alone to succeed, consider reaching out.
<https://www.jessestaffordcoaching.com>

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Feature image prompt (Bing DALL-E): A manager standing at the front of a large conference room filled with a growing team — some familiar faces, many new. The leader looks stretched but composed. Modern office, warm lighting, subtle blue accent. Realistic, professional. Under 380 characters.